



Identifying and challenging negative thought patterns

Oftentimes we think of our thoughts as separate entities, uncontrollable. This can be problematic if we believe untrue thoughts and continually allow ourselves to be drawn into negative self-talk.

Identify distorted thinking

Dr. David Burns, a pioneer in CBT, identifies 10 forms of twisted thinking in his 1999 bestselling book, *The Feeling Good Handbook*. Here's how this kind of thinking can lead to addiction or relapse.

- 1. *Am I engaging in all or nothing thinking?*** This means that you see things in absolute terms: "I failed on my diet so I may as well eat the whole tub of ice cream now".
- 2. *Overgeneralisation:*** a bird poos on your car and you tell yourself, "This is typical, birds are always crapping on my car".
- 3. *Mental filter:*** taking one small event and focusing on it exclusively. "When I didn't drink alcohol on that date, she looked bored, I need to drink to be fun". Unfortunately, zoning in on this one situation, the person forgets the many positive interactions they have had without alcohol.
- 4. *Discounting the positive:*** this involves ignoring or invalidating the good things which have happened to you e.g. "Yes, I got on the team but I'll still never be as good as...".
- 5. *Jumping to conclusions:***

Mind-reading by assuming that someone has reacted badly to you e.g. you tell a joke or tease someone and when they don't laugh, you fear you have offended them and they will never talk to you again.

Fortune telling by saying to yourself "If we get a last-minute free kick, then I will blow it".
- 6. *Magnification:*** exaggerating the importance of shortcomings. "I get nervous when I'm on stage so I will never be able to become a good presenter".
- 7. *Emotional reasoning:*** "I feel lousy therefore I'm a lousy person". When somebody tells themselves that they are worthless they may begin to engage in binge behaviour.





8. **Should statements:** a way to set unattainable standards for ourselves. "I should always be calm, composed and collected".
9. **Labelling:** seeing behaviours as something which defines you. "I acted like a loser so I must be a loser."
10. **Personalisation or blame:** entirely blaming yourself or another for a multi-faceted situation.

How to talk back to these thoughts

1. **Notice the distorted thought which you are carrying out.**
2. **Ask yourself, is it true?** "I feel like I never do anything right but could I list a few things I've done well right now to disprove this theory".
3. **How would I be talking to a friend going through the same situation and thought patterns?**
4. **Experiment by asking people do they ever suffer from something similar** e.g. stage fright.
5. **Think in shades of grey, don't see something as complete success or failure but with an ability to go quite well or poorly and always with opportunity to grow.**
6. **Define terms like 'loser' or 'fool', you will feel better when you see there is no such thing.**
7. **Choose your language wisely, instead of saying 'I shouldn't have made that mistake',** you can say 'it would have been better if I hadn't made that mistake'.
8. **Ask yourself, "are there many factors contributing to this problem?"**
9. **List the advantages and disadvantages of a feeling or thought pattern** e.g. getting angry when your flight is delayed or thinking you must always be perfect.





Your struggle switch and the double arrow

1. ***There's rain when we wanted sunshine.*** We have chosen to turn on our struggle switch and feel annoyed by the fact that the weather isn't perfect for our run.

Could you turn off the switch and do a soul cleansing run in the rain or do a home workout instead?

2. ***The double arrow is a metaphor for the negative emotion caused by an incident or incidences that we keep alive by inflicting a second arrow by replaying them over and over again.***

